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Letter to the Editor

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Author Responses to Problematic Peer Review: A Service Perspective

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Abstract

Peer review reports are not always easy to respond to. A report may press for citations the paper does not need, misread what the paper says, or reflect limited subject expertise. Some reports may also raise questions about undisclosed use of artificial intelligence. This letter asks what authors can do in such cases. It calls the problem a peer review service deadlock. The author must protect the integrity of the manuscript but also needs a timely decision. A short table sets out five ways to respond and the likely consequences of each. The letter closes with practical steps for editors and journals.

Keywords: Scholarly publishing, Peer review service, Author response, Editorial ethics

Peer review is a shared service involving authors, reviewers, editors, and journals. Reviewers carry much of the load and usually work for free. That is why their motives and their relationship with journals have drawn so much attention [1,2]. Most disputes between authors and reviewers are ordinary. They concern interpretation, method, or emphasis and can usually be addressed through evidence and reasoned response. This letter discusses a more difficult case: a peer review service deadlock. It arises when an author receives a request that appears ethically questionable, poorly informed, or unrelated to the manuscript, while still depending on the same review process for a timely publication decision. Unlike an ordinary disagreement, the author must manage both the academic issue and risks to publication, career, funding, or time.

Several distinct problems can produce a deadlock, and they should not be treated as interchangeable. The first is coercive citation. It involves pressure to add references the paper does not need, especially when the reviewer may gain a citation benefit [3]. Another is poor quality or inattentive reviewing. This occurs when the report misses the argument, skips important sections, or describes a paper that the author does not recognize. A third is insufficient subject expertise. This occurs when the reviewer lacks the knowledge needed to assess the topic or method fairly. Possible undisclosed use of artificial intelligence is a fourth concern and should be assessed separately. Bland wording proves nothing, as many human reviewers write that way. The concern becomes stronger only when the comments do not fit the manuscript, contain clear inaccuracies, or conflict with the journal's disclosure policy.

However, caution is required. Reviewers often suggest useful references. A suggestion is not coercive simply because it comes from a reviewer. The warning signs are more specific. The requested citations may have little to do with the study. The reviewer may repeat the request without explanation or focus mainly on their own work. The problem is not hypothetical. A retracted hydrogen energy article stated that irrelevant references had been added at reviewers' request. The retraction notice reported an investigation into citation prompting [4]. Concerns about artificial intelligence require the same restraint. Recent commentary suggests that AI is entering review practice, but a short or formulaic report is weak evidence on its own [5]. What matters to an editor is whether the report is accurate, relevant, and consistent with journal policy. Whatever the cause, the author still has to decide how to respond. As table 1 presents, five options are realistic. Scientific merit is not the only consideration; time to a decision, acceptance prospects, emotional cost, and career or funding deadlines may also matter. The table shows that the same response may carry different costs for different authors. An established author with a flexible timeline may be able to appeal or withdraw. These options can be much harder for a doctoral candidate or early career researcher working under funding or promotion deadlines. For some authors, the right response and the possible response are not the same. That gap creates the deadlock.

Editors and journals, however, can narrow the gap. Authors need a confidential route of appeal that does not send the complaint directly back to the reviewer involved. Editors should also examine requests for self citation or unrelated citations. If a reviewer asks for their own work or for work with no clear bearing on the paper, the editor can ask why it is needed. Journals can monitor the quality of review reports over time. They should also state clearly what use of AI is allowed in review reports, how it must be disclosed, and that reviewers remain responsible for accuracy.

None of this invites authors to fight every hard review. Difficult reviews can improve papers, and critical disagreement is part of the process. Trouble starts when a questionable request meets an author who cannot afford to wait. Authors in that position should answer with evidence rather than irritation. Reviewers should ensure that their comments are relevant and informed. Editors should make an appeal both possible and safe. Journals should monitor the quality of the reviews they commission and state a clear policy on AI use in peer review. Peer review runs on trust, and trust is easier to lose than to rebuild.

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Table 1. Main response alternatives available to authors.

Response alternative	Main criteria	Likely consequences
Full compliance	Relevance and feasibility of the requests, time pressure, and acceptance prospects	Speeds up revision and signals cooperation. It may weaken the paper if the requests are not justified.
Selective compliance	Scientific value of each comment and strength of the author's explanation for points not accepted	Keeps useful changes and protects the core argument. Each point not accepted needs a clear reason.
Confidential appeal	Seriousness of the concern, available evidence, confidence in the appeal process, and available time	May correct a coercive or unsuitable request. It can delay the decision and may not change the outcome.
Withdrawal	Severity of the problem, alternative journals, publication deadlines, and work already invested	Protects the author's independence. Review starts again elsewhere and may cause a long delay.
Minimal response	Comments are generic, repeated, or unrelated, and further exchange has limited value	Saves time and avoids unnecessary changes. It may appear dismissive and reduce the chance of acceptance.

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